Classic Space Game Wing Commander 3 Is Getting a Remaster

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Fans of classic computer games got a big surprise this weekend. At the Portland Retro Gaming Expo, a large event for people who love older video games, an Electronic Arts producer announced that Wing Commander 3: Heart of the Tiger is getting a **remaster**. A **remaster** is a new, improved version of an older game.

Wing Commander was a popular series of space flight games on PC computers in the 1990s. The series had five main games, a dozen **expansions**, books, an animated show and even a movie. But it has mostly been left alone since around the year 2000.

During a panel looking back at the series, producer Jim Vessella said he had found the original master tapes from the making of Wing Commander 3. One fan who was there posted that Vessella found more than 600 source tapes in the company's **archives** and has been restoring them.

Vessella told the crowd that a 30th **anniversary remaster** is on the way. The video scenes will be cleaned up, and the game will run at 60 **frames per second**, which makes motion look smoother. It will also include improvements made by fans after the game came out, plus "the Kilrathi Saga," which suggests the first three games may be included.

In the game, players fly as a space pilot named Christopher Blair in a war between humans and the Kilrathi, an empire of giant cat-like aliens. The game is famous for its **live-action** movie scenes starring real actors, including Mark Hamill, who played Luke Skywalker in Star Wars.

Kotaku, which reported the news, noted that the reveal was a little unusual, since Vessella did not work on the original series. The series' creator, Chris Roberts, now leads a different space game called Star Citizen.

Word Treasure

remaster -- A new, improved version of an older game, movie or recording.

expansions -- Add-ons that give a game new levels, stories or features.

archives -- Places where old records, files or recordings are stored.

anniversary -- The date that marks a certain number of years since something happened.

frames per second -- How many pictures a screen shows each second; more frames make motion look smoother.

live-action -- Filmed with real actors instead of animation.

Background you need

Video games from the 1990s often ran on older computers and stored videos in low quality, so they can look blurry today.

A remaster updates an old game with better pictures and smoother play while keeping the original story.

Some 1990s games mixed gameplay with filmed scenes starring real actors, which was new and exciting at the time.

Retro gaming events bring together fans of older games to play, trade and hear news about classic series.

Break it down

LEAD: Wing Commander 3 is getting a 30th anniversary remaster
KEY EVENT: Announcement during a retrospective panel at the Portland Retro Gaming Expo
+- WHO: Electronic Arts producer Jim Vessella
+- HOW: Master tapes found and restored, reportedly more than 600
DETAILS: Cleaned-up video, 60 frames per second, fan improvements, "the Kilrathi Saga"
CONTEXT: Wing Commander was a popular 1990s PC space series with live-action scenes starring Mark Hamill
OPEN QUESTION: Why the reveal came from a producer outside the original team

Why it matters

Remasters let new players experience classic games and help preserve gaming history that might otherwise be lost. Finding old master tapes can save the original work for the future.

Test what you remember

1. Where was the Wing Commander 3 remaster announced?

- (A) At the Portland Retro Gaming Expo
- (B) At a school science fair
- (C) At a movie theater
- (D) On a TV news show

2. Who announced the remaster?

- (A) Producer Jim Vessella
- (B) Mark Hamill
- (C) Chris Roberts
- (D) Christopher Blair

3. What did Vessella find?

- (A) A new alien species
- (B) A lost game console
- (C) A secret level
- (D) The original master tapes from making the game

4. How fast will the remastered game run?

- (A) 30 frames per second
- (B) 120 frames per second
- (C) 10 frames per second
- (D) 60 frames per second

5. Who are the Kilrathi in the game?

- (A) Robots from Mars
- (B) An empire of giant cat-like aliens
- (C) A team of human pilots
- (D) A rock band

6. Why did Kotaku call the reveal a little unusual?

- (A) Vessella did not work on the original series
- (B) Fans did not attend
- (C) It was announced underwater
- (D) The game was never released

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: D 4: D 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Jim Vessella, EA producer: Says a 30th anniversary remaster is on the way using the restored master tapes.**

2. **Kotaku: Notes the reveal was a little unusual because Vessella did not work on the original series.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):